

BALLET ▼

FROZEN MAGIC

The Nutcracker on Ice **makes its India debut at NMACC, turning a theatre into a 14-tonne ice rink for a blend of skating and storytelling**

This Christmas, one of the world's beloved ballets arrives in India as *The Nutcracker on Ice* makes its Indian debut at the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre from December 4-14. Blending elite ice skating with storytelling, it transforms The Grand Theatre into a glittering ice rink.

Presented by the Imperial Ice Stars, the production is directed by Tony Mercer, whose vision emerged from a desire to bring the excitement of elite ice skating to the theatrical stage. "Being from the world of theatre, I thought how wonderful it would be if you could see that on a theatre stage, somewhere intimate, with lighting, decoration and costume," he recalls.

That impulse shaped his approach to theatre on ice, prioritising narrative and atmosphere over spectacle alone. Drawn to dance-led storytelling and to the music of Tchaikovsky, *The Nutcracker* became a natural choice.

> Performed on ice by 23 elite skaters, **the ballet adds a physical vocabulary** unavailable to traditional dance

Set in early 20th-century St Petersburg, the story follows young Marie, whose Christmas Eve gift leads her into an enchanted world of toy soldiers, snowflakes and dancing sweets. Performed on ice by 23 skaters, the ballet adds a physical vocabulary unavailable to traditional dance. "Ice allows us stillness, movement at incredible speed and a sense of surprise," says Mercer. "On that stage, there will be 14 tonnes of frozen water," he adds.

At the heart of *The Nutcracker on Ice* is Mercer's respect for the audience. His passion for creating an intimate experience, combined with visual magic, promises a festive treat that can connect generations, leaving a lasting impact on anyone who steps into the theatre.

—Nikhil Sardana

From Dec. 4-14 at the NMACC, Mumbai

FESTIVAL ▼

Timeless Kabir

THE MAHINDRA KABIRA FESTIVAL IN VARANASI WILL CELEBRATE THE 15TH-CENTURY MYSTIC POET'S IDEAS AND TEACHINGS

from Indian classical ragas to Carnatic music and jazz. As Sanjoy K. Roy, MD of Teamwork Arts, says, "Kabir's words remain timeless. They heal, provoke and inspire reflection in a world that constantly changes."

Some of the musical experiences include Kabiriyat—a captivating qawwali performance by Rehmat-e-Nusrat, a Kumaon-based ensemble; a sitar performance by the acclaimed Hidayat Husain Khan, son of Ustad Vilayat Khan; 'Kabir the Julaha: Verses from the Loom', a storytelling and musical performance by Shivangini Yeashu Yuvraj, featuring Isha Priya Singh; Kabir Baani by folk musician Mahesha Ram, a soulful sarod performance by Debasmita Bhattacharya among others, culminating with the finale by Agam, the pioneering Carnatic progressive rock band.



ON THE BANKS OF ETERNITY
A scene from a past edition of the Mahindra Kabira Festival

"The Mahindra Kabira Festival has evolved from a curated heritage event into a major cultural platform. This edition features a bigger, more diverse programme, an expanded roster of Indian and international artists; and strengthened community and education initiatives," says Jay Shah, VP, head of Cultural Outreach, Mahindra & Mahindra. ■

—Deepali Dhingra

The Mahindra Kabira Festival will take place from Dec. 19-21